

Who Emits, How Much, and What's Changing

Fossil fuels & industry · 1750–2024

A data-forward briefing for policy analysts, climate negotiators, and sustainability researchers.

>35 Bt/yr

global CO₂ today

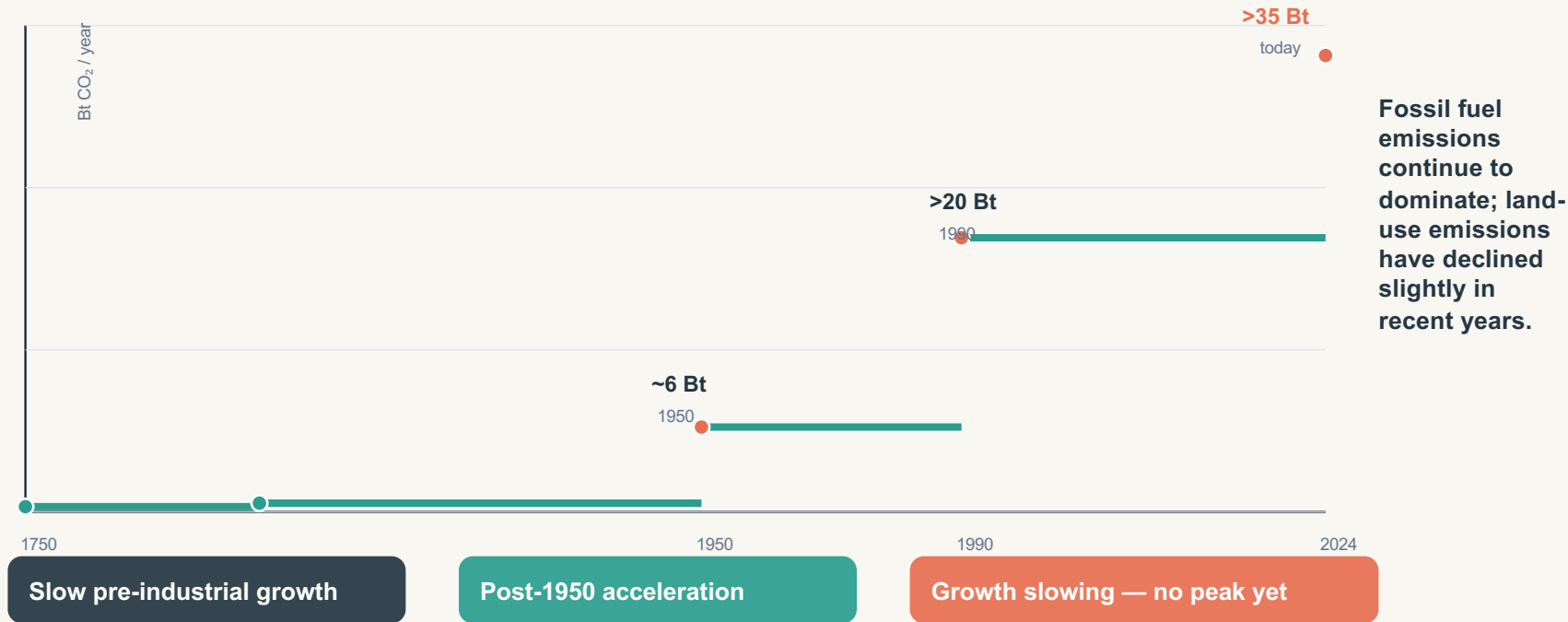
~31%

China share, 2024

150×

per capita gap

Global CO₂ Emissions Grew from 6 Bt in 1950 to Over 35 Bt Today



Europe and the US Fell from 90% of Emissions in 1900 to Under One-Third Today

>90%

Europe + US share in 1900

>85%

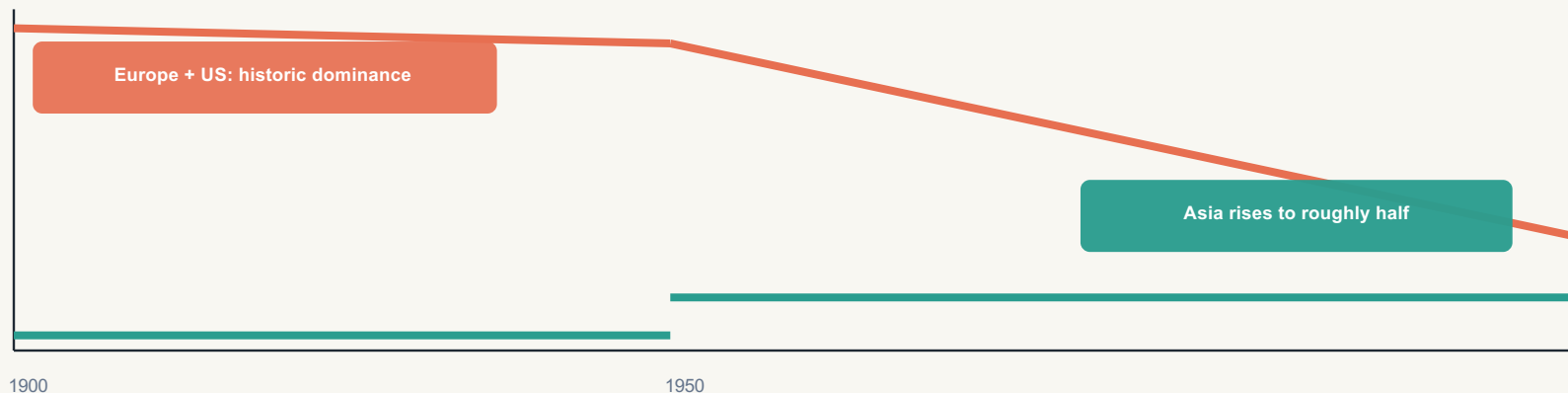
Europe + US share in 1950

<1/3

Europe + US share today

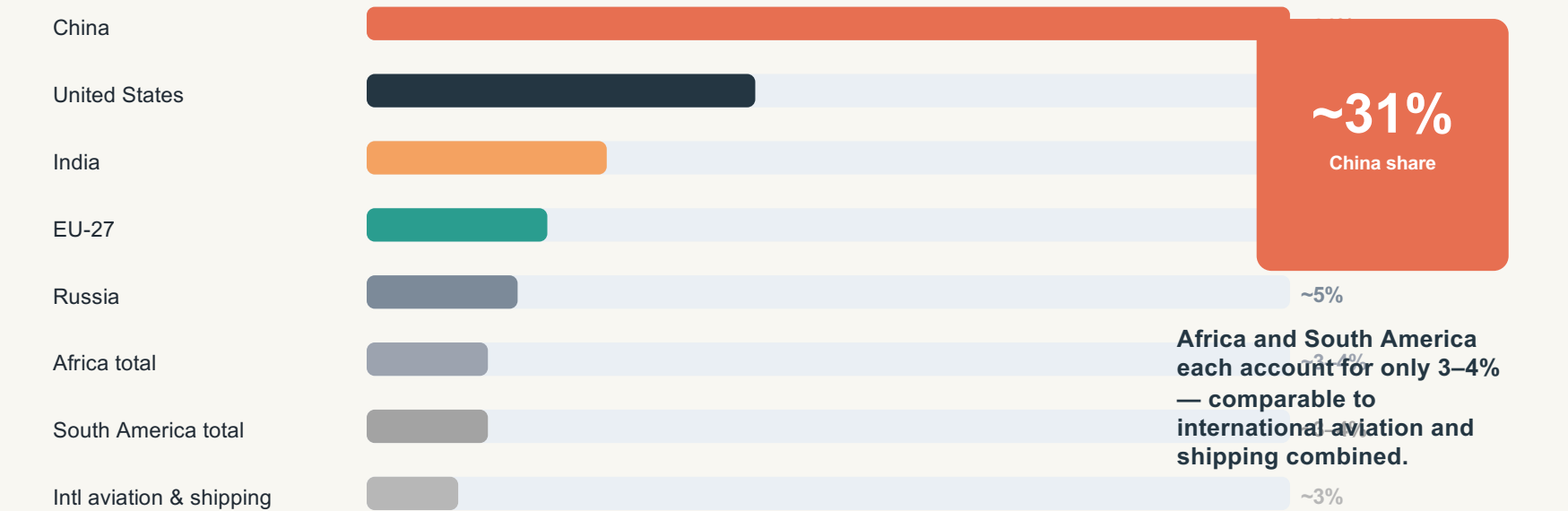
~1/2

Asia share today, led by China



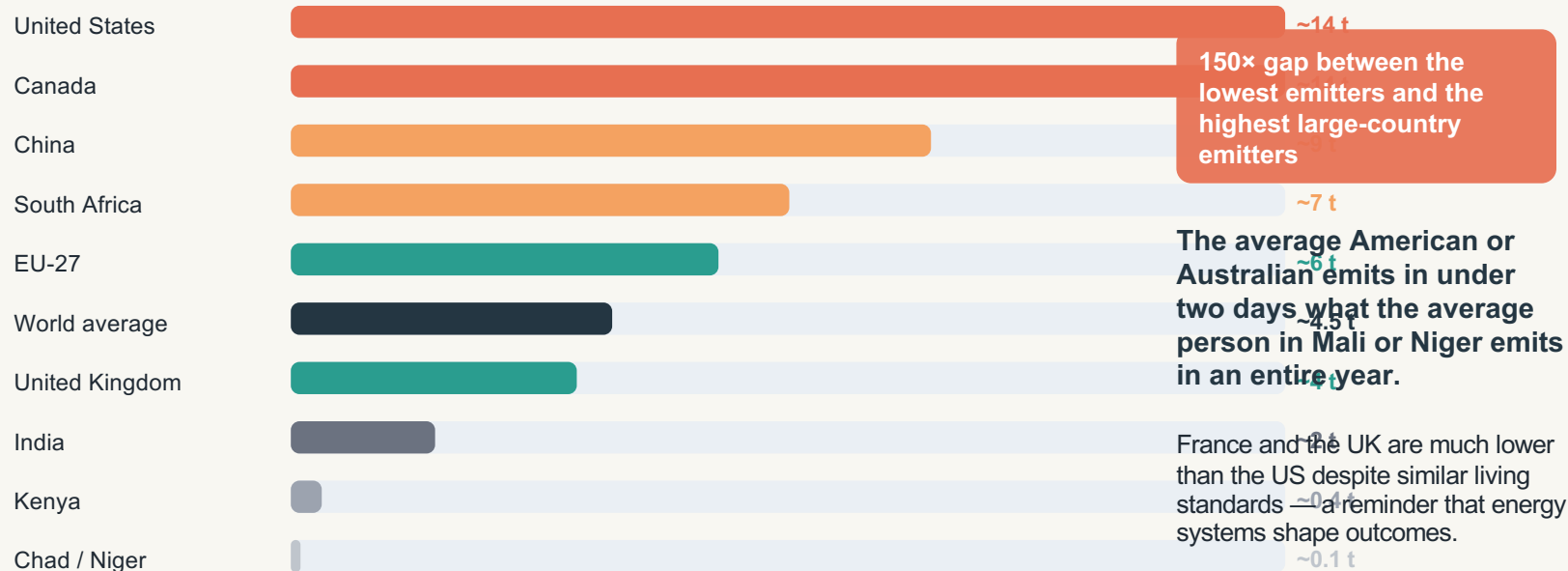
Visual placeholder: stacked-area chart of regional shares over time, emphasizing Europe/North America decline and Asia's rise.

China Now Emits More Than One-Quarter of Global CO₂

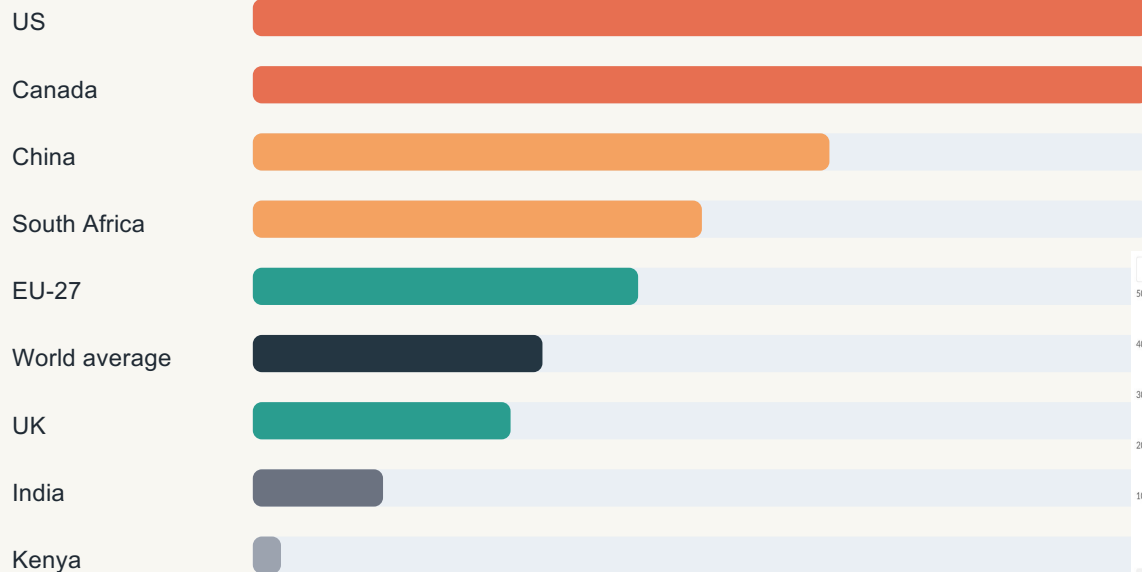


Treemap interpretation: one country now occupies the largest annual-emissions block.

Per Capita Emissions Range from 0.1 t in Chad to ~14 t in the US and Canada



Per Capita Emissions Vary Widely: ~14 t in the US vs. ~9 t in China and ~2 t in India



Largest total emitter ≠ highest per person

China's per capita emissions remain below the US, while India remains very low at ~2 t/person.

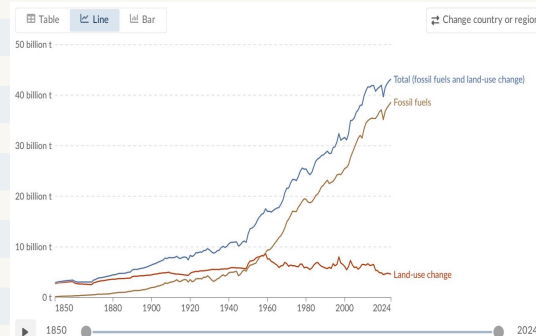


Figure reference: per capita CO₂ emissions over time

2024 Snapshot: Many Western Nations Cut Emissions While Parts of Asia and Africa Grew

Declines

US, much of the EU, and UK



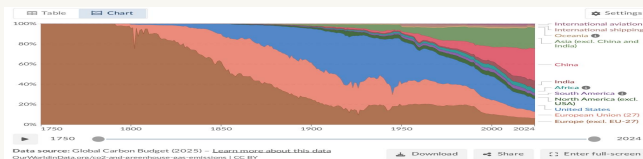
Increases

Russia, parts of Southeast Asia, and several African nations



Large increases

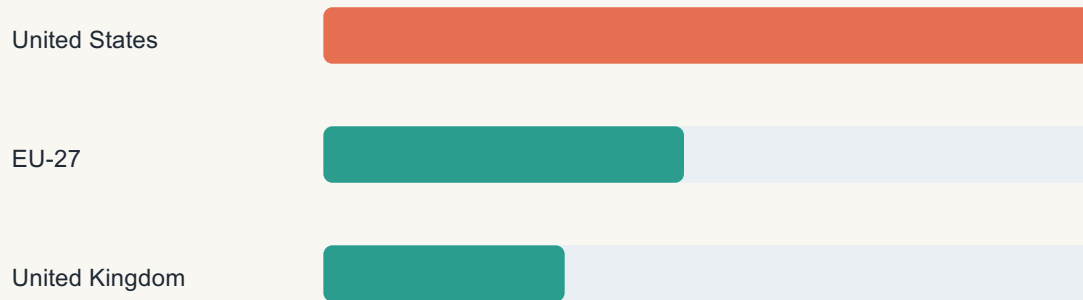
Central Asia region — some countries exceeding 10%



Visual placeholder: diverging bar / choropleth map — blue for declines, orange/red for increases.

Mixed signals: developed-country reductions were offset by growth in parts of Asia, the Middle East, and Africa.

Energy Mix Explains Why France and the UK Emit Far Less Per Capita Than Germany or the US



Available per capita figures show the scale; the mechanism is qualitative in the source brief.

Why similar prosperity can produce different emissions

- France, the UK, and Portugal are much lower per capita than Germany, the Netherlands, or the US.
- A higher share of nuclear and renewable electricity lowers fossil-fuel dependence.
- Energy policy and technology choices can decouple prosperity from emissions.

Key Takeaways: Responsibility Is Shared but Unequal

No peak yet

Global CO₂ emissions from fossil fuels exceed 35 Bt/yr and have not yet peaked.

Annual dominance shifted

China is the largest annual emitter; its per capita emissions remain below the US.

Historical responsibility matters

Europe and the US dominated emissions historically, exceeding 90% in 1900.

Per capita gaps persist

A 150× gap remains between the lowest emitters and highest large-country emitters.

Policy choices matter

Energy systems can decouple prosperity from emissions.

Policy implication: mitigation responsibility is universal, but capacity, historical contribution, and per-person emissions differ sharply.